

Sunburn - Female (Adult)

Algorithm 1034 | Adult (18 years and older) | Gender at birth: Female

Definition

- Sunburn severity assessment decomposed from NHS.UK's published when-to-get-help guidance.
- Adult patient.
- Female.

Initial assessment

1. [OPEN_TEXT] What is the person's exact age and sex, are they pregnant, how long was the heat/sun exposure, what area is affected, and are there blisters, eye/face involvement, fever, vomiting, dizziness, confusion, reduced urine, or child/vulnerable-person safeguarding concerns?
2. [YES_NO] Is the skin blistered?
3. [TEMPERATURE] Has a temperature been measured? If so, what was it?

Triage and redirect questions

1. Redirect → Burns - Thermal

Is this a burn from direct heat, flame, hot liquid, or steam rather than sun exposure?

A non-solar thermal burn requires the authored Burns - Thermal pathway.

2. Redirect → Burns - Chemical

Was the injury caused by an acid or another chemical rather than sun exposure?

A chemical burn requires the authored Burns - Chemical pathway and immediate substance-specific decontamination precautions.

1. Disposition level 100

Is this an electrical or lightning injury, or is there confusion, fainting, a very high temperature with no sweating, or a rapid heartbeat suggesting heatstroke rather than simple sunburn?

Electrical and lightning injuries retain a conservative emergency disposition because their authored protocol is not in the generated catalog. NHS.UK also notes severe sunburn can progress to heat exhaustion and heatstroke, which needs emergency care.

1. Disposition level 70

Is the skin blistered or swollen, is the temperature very high or does the caller feel hot, cold, or shivery, does the caller feel very tired, dizzy, or sick, is there a headache or muscle cramps, or is the patient a baby or young child?

NHS.UK sunburn guidance lists these as reasons for an urgent primary-care review or urgent clinical review call.

1. Disposition level 15

Is this mild-to-moderate sunburn without blistering or the features above?

NHS.UK guidance describes most sunburn as resolving within about a week with home care.

Advice

Qatar emergency heat-illness response

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 and do not drive for confusion, seizure, collapse, abnormal breathing, very hot skin, inability to drink, severe dehydration, or an unwell infant/child. Move to shade or air conditioning, remove excess clothing, and cool with water and airflow while following 999 instructions. Do not use ice directly or give oral fluids if drowsy, vomiting, seizing, or unsafe to swallow. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.
- Call Back If: worsening confusion or collapse; seizure or abnormal breathing; inability to drink or markedly reduced urine.

Urgent sunburn review

- Cool the skin, stay hydrated, and arrange same-day medical review, especially for blistering or a young child.
- Call Back If: fever worsens; increasing dizziness.

Governed care for mild sunburn

- Leave the sun, cool skin with a cool shower or damp cloth, wear loose clothing, and maintain usual fluids if not restricted. Use only a bland unperfumed moisturiser on intact skin and do not burst blisters or apply ice. Medicine requires age, weight, pregnancy, allergy, kidney/liver disease, dehydration, and current-medicine checks.
- Call Back If: large blisters, facial/eye involvement, fever, dizziness, vomiting, reduced urine, or feeling very unwell.

First aid

- Call Qatar emergency services on 999 and do not drive for confusion, seizure, collapse, abnormal breathing, very hot skin, inability to drink, severe dehydration, or an unwell infant/child. Move to shade or air conditioning,

remove excess clothing, and cool with water and airflow while following 999 instructions. Do not use ice directly or give oral fluids if drowsy, vomiting, seizing, or unsafe to swallow. Call Qatar 999 now, follow the call-taker's ambulance and emergency-transport instructions, and do not self-drive. Do not delay emergency care.

References

- NHS.UK, "Sunburn", <https://www.nhs.uk/conditions/sunburn/> (page last reviewed 24 November 2025)

Provenance

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